

The End(s) of Genre

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Abstract This article presents a critique of the commonplace trope that holds genre to have declined in relevance under modernism. Contrary to the widespread notion that composers' repudiation of received tradition rendered the very idea of genre categories obsolete, this article argues that such categories have never ceased playing a decisive role in the production, circulation, and reception of post-1945 art music. In interrogating the assumptions that underpin the "decline-of-genre" thesis, this article underlines the utility that renewed attention to genre and its framing effects may have for the analysis of this repertoire. To this end, an alternative to standard theories of genre is advanced, one that draws on actor-network theory to destabilize categories too often conceived as fixed, solid, and binding. This revised theory of genre is applied to Gérard Grisey's six-part cycle, *Les espaces acoustiques* (1974–85). Habitually regarded as an exemplar of spectral music, Grisey's cycle may be understood as participating in a number of additional generic contexts at the same time. Taking such generic overdetermination into account not only sheds light on the range of conflicting interpretations that *Les espaces acoustiques* affords but also suggests how music analysis might better address the heterogeneous contexts and multiple listener competences that this and other musics engage.

1.

A RECURRING TROPE in the discourse of modernism centers on the decline of genre. The story goes like this: with the rejection of received tradition, categories that had once shaped the production, circulation, and reception of Western art music appeared increasingly irrelevant to composers and audiences alike. Obituaries for the concept date back to the early years of the twentieth century. Benedetto Croce, in his 1902 *Estetica come scienza dell'espressione e linguistica generale*, argued that interpreting artworks on the basis of shared features or social functions was misguided. Each work constituted its own genus and as such warranted consideration on its own terms. "All the books dealing with classifications and systems of the arts," he famously declared, "could be burned without any loss" (115). Some decades later Theodor Adorno picked up this discursive thread, observing in his *Aesthetic Theory* (1997) that the drive toward individuation, while predating the advent of modernism, had

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accelerated to such a degree over the past hundred years that the very idea of generalization in art had become difficult to maintain: "What befell the categories of the tragic and the comic testifies to the decline of aesthetic genres as such. Art has been caught up in the total process of nominalism's advance ever since the medieval *ordo* was broken up. The universal is no longer granted art through types, and older types are being drawn into the whirlpool" (199).¹ Claims regarding the decline of genre under modernism continue to be voiced up to the present day. Jim Samson's entry on genre in the *New Grove*, for instance, avers that works of twentieth-century music are "less concerned to exemplify genres than to make their own statement," adding that "genre definitions and classification systems have played a subsidiary role in discussions of 20th-century art music" (2001, 658). Similar assertions are not difficult to come by.²

No doubt the most thorough exposition of what might be dubbed the "decline-of-genre" thesis is to be found in the writings of Carl Dahlhaus. For Dahlhaus, as for other authors, the traditional system of genre categories was a belated casualty of the principle of aesthetic autonomy that took root in Western art music circa 1800. Freedom from external, social constraints steadily eroded the meaning and force of groupings predicated on such constraints. "In older, functional music," Dahlhaus remarked, "a work was primarily an example of a genre. . . . A work formed not so much an isolated, closed whole, an individuality enduring in itself, as, rather, it exemplified a type" (1982, 15). Music's emancipation from such heteronomous pressures, however, turned on its head the relation that had hitherto obtained between token and type: "Every genre fades to an abstract generalization, derived from individual structures after they have accumulated; and finally, in the twentieth century, individual structures submit only under duress to being allocated to any genre" (15). The culmination of this process of individuation was to be seen in the music of the postwar avant-garde. Writing in 1968, Dahlhaus observed how "in the last decade and a half the works of the musical avant-garde have no longer presented themselves as sonatas or symphonies but as 'Constellations', 'Figures' or 'Prisms'" (1987, 32). The erasure of genre's verbal trace ratified its receding importance in musical practice. As composers found themselves compelled "to look incessantly for new titles" (32), one of the last vestiges of Western art music's allegiance to traditional genre categories passed into oblivion.

¹ Adorno, in a characteristic dialectical move, regards the progressive individuation of artworks as a universal attribute of art: "The drive toward nominalism does not originate in reflection but in the artwork's own impulse, and to this extent it originates in a universal of art. From time immemorial, art has sought to rescue the special: progressive particularization was immanent to it" (1997, 201).

² See, for instance, Samson 1989, 229; Talbot 2000, 174–75; Moore 2001, 437; and Lippman 2006, 151. For similar claims regarding modern literature, see Blanchot 1995, 141; and the essays collected in Dambre and Gosselin-Noat 2001.

Belief in genre's obsolescence has largely been internalized by the practices of music theory and analysis. As Samson observes, the kind of "work-centered perspective" to which these disciplines subscribe makes them largely impervious to the claims of genre. This is particularly true of analytic discourse on twentieth-century music (and post-1945 music more specifically), which has tended "to minimize the power of genre" (2001, 658). Analyses that do continue to invoke traditional generic categories (concerto, opera, string quartet, oratorio, etc.) typically do so not in order to show how pieces exemplify their norms but to show how they transgress or repudiate them.³ But by far the most common way that analytical discourse deals with the question of genre with regard to this repertoire is to omit it from consideration in the first place. Belief in the autonomy of the work, according to which intrapopus, "contextual" factors are taken to be of greater significance than extrapopus, "communal" ones (such as genre), would appear to be foundational for much analytical practice. Joseph Dubiel's comments on the music of Milton Babbitt are representative: "The understanding of this music is unlikely ever to be facilitated at any level by familiarity with 'stylistic' norms to the same extent as the understanding of older music" (1992, 121). With this guiding assumption in place, the goal of analysis becomes one of explicating the immanent structural principles governing a work. The idea that the music might meaningfully engage with some broader generic impulse is rarely if ever entertained.

The present article challenges the notion of genre's decline under modernism. My principal contention is this: the groupings enacted by genre classifications, far from disappearing or lapsing into irrelevance, continue to shape our understanding of modernist music, up to and including its most recent expressions. If it appears otherwise, this is because such groupings are misrecognized, disavowed in theory even as they continue to be produced and reproduced in practice. In critically interrogating the assumptions that underpin pronouncements regarding the obsolescence of genre, this article further seeks to identify the utility that renewed attention to genre and its framing effects may have for the analysis and interpretation of this repertoire. In other words, in calling the purported end of genre into question, I seek to uncover the ends to which it may yet be put. With this goal in mind, the second section of this article presents an alternative to standard accounts of musical genre, one that draws on the insights of actor-network theory (ANT) to destabilize entities that are all too often conceived as fixed, solid objects, as static containers into which pieces of music are deposited.⁴ I then

³ Which is not to deny the insights that such an approach may provide. See, for instance, Bauer 1997; Metzger 2000, esp. 103–108; Reyland 2008; and Uno Everett 2009.

⁴ The theory of genre elaborated below is also informed by the work of Erving Goffman (on framing) and Pierre Bourdieu (on symbolic capital). While the coupling of Bour-

dieu's theories with those of ANT in the present article may seem jarring, given that they are widely taken as representing two antithetical poles in recent French social theory, I would contend that the divergent perspectives they offer have the potential to disclose each other's blind spots. ANT's emphasis on the performativity of social ties

apply this revised theory of genre to a discussion of Gérard Grisey's six-part cycle, *Les espaces acoustiques* (1974–85). Of particular note are the multiplicity of generic contexts the work invokes and the way these contexts frame our perception and interpretation of Grisey's music. Finally, the conclusion sketches some of the implications that the theory of genre presented here may have for music theory and analysis more broadly. Conceiving genre as something that is enacted and not given a priori, as something that is defined in "relational" terms and not "substantive" ones (Bourdieu 1998, 3), sheds light on the conflicts of interpretation to which music can give rise—conflicts that take place not just between separate persons and groups but within the individual subject, as different musical competences and different sites of aesthetic investment intersect, interact, and interfere with one another.

2.

Let us begin our reassessment of genre's alleged demise by scrutinizing Dahlhaus's claim that "the disintegration of genres . . . force[d] composers to look incessantly for new titles" (1987, 32). Implicit in this statement is the uncontroversial notion that titles, along with other "paramusical" markers, have traditionally served to indicate to which genre a given work belongs. More dubious, however, is Dahlhaus's assumption of a causal relation linking genre to work title, such that the dissolution of the former spells the desuetude of the latter. By this logic, the proliferation of works bearing names like "Constellations," "Figures," and "Prisms" during the 1950s and 1960s represented the externalized, verbal manifestation of an underlying musical reality, a visible symptom of the crisis in the traditional system of musical genres.⁵ As long as this system remained intact, work titles followed as a matter of course. But once it dissolved, the conventions that had hitherto governed the naming of pieces no longer applied. The problem with figuring the relation between genre and work title in this way is that it disregards the performative dimension of the names composers give works. A title, by signaling to listeners the genre to which a piece belongs, serves a "rhetorical" or communicative function, in addition to a taxonomic one (Kallberg 1988, 243). Viewed in this light, the search for "new titles" that Dahlhaus remarks upon did not passively reflect the "disintegration of genres" but actively participated in—and per-

provides a useful corrective to Bourdieu's tendency to assume the existence of relatively stable social fields that stand above individuals and shape their conduct. On the other hand, Bourdieu's emphasis on socialization and the symbolic dimension of power relations provides an equally useful corrective to ANT's rather thin account of the interests and motives that animate actors.

⁵ While not explicitly named, it is likely that Pierre Boulez was the figure Dahlhaus had in mind when writing this passage, considering the close resemblance of these

ersatz titles to Boulez's *Figures-Doubles-Prismes* and the "Constellation-Miroir" movement of his Third Piano Sonata. Even so, it seems clear that Dahlhaus intended for these titles to be construed as representative of a broader trend that extended beyond the oeuvre of a single composer. (My thanks to both Robert Adlington and one of the anonymous reviewers of this article for having drawn my attention to this connection, which I had previously overlooked.)

haps even expedited—this process. Abjuring conventional work titles like *symphony* or *concerto* may have been a sign of the decline of these genres, but it may just as well have been a way of strategically disorienting audiences or a means of directing their attention toward the music's immanent, "contextual" structure instead of its "communal" features.

Yet the fact that the naming practice identified by Dahlhaus had itself become a cliché by the time he wrote his essay on genre and new music in the late 1960s suggests that it represented more than a tactic that composers exploited to frustrate the ingrained habits of listeners. The widespread use of plural-form nouns, more often than not drawn from scientific or technical discourse, pointed to something that bound such works together beyond their joint refusal of conventional generic titles. As Dahlhaus observes, the abstract character of titles like "Ramifications," "Interpolations," or "Structures" hints at a common aesthetic orientation, one characterized by a lingering commitment to the idea of absolute music. A name like "Constellations" may have been intended "to designate a special, individual shape not tied to a genre," but its refusal of conventional genre markers was not a sign of its "inclination towards programme music," since the referent of the title was "abstract enough not to contradict the essence of instrumental music" (1987, 32). To the extent that such plural-form titles retained some vestige of referentiality, it was an oddly reflexive, empty sort of referentiality, one that folded back in on the work instead of pointing outside it. It was as if such titles furnished a concrete verbal figuration of the work's abstract structure, their referential content being nothing other than music's nonreferential form. Furthermore, the fact that this naming practice was so widespread made it easily recognizable as such. The abandonment of older, generic titles in favor of ostensibly uncoded, non- or antigereneric ones may not have confounded listeners as much as signaled to them in advance that such works should not be expected to adhere to the norms of conventional genres. Titles that at first blush appear nondescript or neutral proved no less effective in situating works and thereby framing them for listeners. Even if such titles sought to frustrate conventionalized expectations, they instituted their own set of negative expectations in turn.

The foregoing suggests that the works Dahlhaus grouped together in order to demonstrate the decline of genre itself constituted a genre—most likely what would nowadays be placed under the rubrics of serial and/or post-serial music. Support for this contention may be found in the fact that the naming practice identified by Dahlhaus was scarcely universal. On the contrary: works bearing such familiar titles as *symphony*, *concerto*, and *sonata* continued to be produced in abundance during the 1950s and 1960s.⁶ That

⁶ Published in 1968, the same year that Dahlhaus's essay "New Music and the Problem of Musical Genre" was originally written, were such works as Roger Sessions's *Symphony* no. 8, Alfred Schnittke's *Violin Sonata* no. 2, David

Diamond's *Violin Concerto* no. 3, Poul Ruders's *Requiem*, William Schuman's *Symphony* no. 9, Krzysztof Penderecki's *String Quartet* no. 2, and Gian Francesco Malipiero's *Flute Concerto*.

such conventional genre designations proved so resilient relativizes Dahlhaus's claims regarding the decline of genre. So too does the unabated proliferation of genres and subgenres within other musical traditions, such as popular music or jazz. It would appear, then, that his thesis regarding the demise of genre only applied to a small, circumscribed class of works. Or, to be more precise, it would appear that Dahlhaus carved out from the universe of musical texts a group of pieces defined by their adherence to the requirements of his thesis, by their self-conscious repudiation of traditional genre markers. But this repudiation was itself a genre marker. The denial of genre was less the symptom of a broad, historical process than a distinguishing characteristic of a particular body of musical texts.

A number of implications follow from this point. One is that what Dahlhaus and others mistook for the "deterioration of genre" was in fact the deterioration of a certain conception of genre, the deterioration of a specific, historically contingent way of ordering the universe of musical texts. What changed was not the impulse to group such texts together, or the tendency to interpret them against the backdrop of this broader grouping, but the criteria used to perform such acts. That Dahlhaus should have mistaken the decline of a particular way of constituting genres for the decline of genre tout court is somewhat surprising, given that much of his writing on the subject explored precisely this issue—namely, the contingent nature of the criteria used to delineate different categories of music. Time and again he stressed that the musical and extramusical determinants put to work in distinguishing one genre from another were subject to change over time.⁷ Elsewhere in his essay on genre and new music, Dahlhaus argues that the practice of genre classification underwent a fundamental transformation in the middle years of the eighteenth century. Whereas "prior to the seventeenth century function, text and texture [were] the primary factors that determine a genre," beginning in the latter half of the eighteenth century "scoring and form" became increasingly central to genre classifications (1987, 33). But instead of seeing the displacement of traditional musical categories at the beginning of the twentieth century as signaling a comparable change in how such groupings were constituted, Dahlhaus argues that it signaled nothing less than the breakdown of the idea of genre. Works like Webern's *Sechs Stücke für grosses Orchester* op. 6 severed the "established connection between a formal model and a type of scoring" (40), the principal means of identifying genre categories in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries. "Webern's procedure," Dahlhaus goes on to remark, "had a historical significance which no one was able to perceive in 1910. It meant nothing less than that the aesthetic, composi-

7 See, for instance, Dahlhaus's statement that "the relevance of genres, their formative effect, is not the same for all times, just as on the other hand the criteria, choice, and weighting of features by means of which genres are determined [likewise] changes" ("Ist demnach die Relevanz der

Gattungen, ihre prägende Wirkung, nicht zu allen Zeiten gleich, so wechseln andererseits auch die Kriterien, die Auswahl und das Gewicht der Merkmale, nach denen Gattungen bestimmt werden") (1973, 844).

tional and technical basis of musical genres, *and not of individual genres but of the concept of the genre taken as a whole*, had begun to crumble” (40, emphasis mine). Yet it remains unclear why the break with this particular way of classifying musical texts and practices, one that Dahlhaus himself admits dates only from the late eighteenth century, should mark the beginning of the end of genre as such. If the conjunction of “formal model” and “type of scoring” was rendered defunct by the experiments of Webern and other modernist composers, it does not follow that this precludes some other determinant (or set of determinants) from playing a similar role in the definition of genre.

More significant, the fact that works alleged to have broken with genre formed a coherent, identifiable genre of their own testifies to what Jason Toynbee has dubbed genre’s “inevitability” (2000: 107), its status as a necessary ground against which musical conduct takes shape and acquires meaning. To a certain extent, this inevitability is a by-product of the relational nature of genre. I explore this issue in greater detail in the next section, but for the moment let it suffice to point out that any work aiming to declare its independence from a particular genre necessarily ratifies a latent connection with the latter through the very act of negation that it performs. “In order to exist as such,” Tzvetan Todorov writes, “the transgression requires a law—precisely the one that is to be violated” (1990, 15).⁸ The fact that groups are defined by their difference with respect to other groups means that any claim of radical autonomy, by engaging in the same logic of differentiation, creates new groupings even as it endeavors to dissolve older ones. Even were a musical text (or practice) to accomplish the difficult but not impossible feat of removing itself entirely from the gravitational pull of established genre categories, in doing so it would immediately define some new category, one delineated on the basis of its refusal of other categories. Toynbee makes this clear in his discussion of “free music,” an improvisational practice that emerged in the 1970s, in the interstices between avant-garde jazz and contemporary art music. As Toynbee points out, the practitioners of free improvisation strenuously deny that their music fits in any discrete, definable genre category. But what is repressed in theory returns in practice, in the form of shared stylistic idioms, conventions governing the music’s mode of presentation, performance techniques, and so forth (2000: 108–9). One might go a step further and posit that the very denial of genre in the discourse of free music’s practitioners is itself a genre convention, much in the same way as the “non-” or “antigeneric” titles cited by Dahlhaus turn out to be generic markers themselves.

⁸ Susan McClary makes a similar point when she observes that “atonal projects themselves derive their meaning from tonality,” to the extent that the latter represents “the seductive idol against which composers and listeners were expected to practice apostasy” (2000, 140).

Nyman 1974	Experimental/Avant-garde
Danuser 1987	Traditionalism/"Mittlere Musik"/Modern/Avant-garde
Borio 1993	Modern/Avant-garde
Born 1995	Modern/Postmodern/Popular
Straus 1999	Serial/Tonal/Atonal/Experimental
Broyles 2004	Establishment/Maverick/Serial
Simmons 2004	Traditionalist/Modernist
Gann 2006	Uptown/Downtown/Midtown
Lehman 2006	Classical Modernism/Avant-garde/Postmodernism/Reflexive Modernism
Metzer 2009	Modernism/Postmodernism/Late Modernism

Figure 1. Partitionings of post-1945 art music

Corroborating the inevitability of generic groupings is their persistence in the discourse of contemporary art music, albeit typically in disguised form. A survey of texts on post-1945 art music indicates that classificatory schemes, far from disappearing, have become a ubiquitous feature in accounts of the subject. Figure 1 lists some of the diverse groupings that have been proposed to bring order to this repertoire. Each of these elevates some determinant—be it musical, aesthetic, social, institutional, or historical—to serve as the principal criterion for partitioning the field of new music. And each presupposes a broader grouping, one that subsumes all the categories listed into the metagenre of “new” or “contemporary” music, as well as a broader division, one that separates this field of musical activity apart from other metagenres (such as jazz, rock, folk, country, dance music, etc.).⁹ That the categories listed in Figure 1 are seldom referred to as genres, more typically labeled as “tendencies,” “movements,” schools, or “aesthetics,” does little more than indicate the degree to which discourse on post-1945 music has internalized the “rhetoric of autonomy” that is itself one of contemporary music’s defining generic traits (Wilson 2004). But this does not diminish the import of the various labels and classificatory schemes that circulate around this repertoire. Communal patterns of musical activity, no matter how vocally they are rejected in the discourse of contemporary music, reemerge in the form of a metalanguage that shapes the limits of this discourse.

3.

A major factor motivating the suspicion of genre in modernist aesthetics is the way the concept has traditionally been employed. The tendency to view genre as a set of rigid, taxonomic schemata standing above and outside individual texts, imposing certain strictures upon them, has done much to discredit the notion in both theory and practice. Conceiving genre in such a

⁹ Though it should be noted that this broader metageneric distinction goes unmentioned in all of the texts cited in Figure 1, save Born 1995.

prescriptive fashion transforms it into an instrument of symbolic violence, whose baleful effects may be seen in the sanctions that musicians incur when they stray from the norms promulgated by the genre with which they are affiliated or in the exclusions that result from the habitual identification of certain genres with certain social groups.¹⁰ But even something as simple and apparently unproblematic as asserting that a work belongs to a genre is not devoid of the specter of this violence, insofar as the ascription of the specific to the general that occurs when a text is classed within a genre necessarily minimizes certain features and exaggerates others. No text, after all, adheres in all its details to the generic ideal; some degree of distortion is inevitable if the peculiarities of the former are to be brought into alignment with the demands of the latter.

Given this legacy, it is small wonder that genre has often been regarded as an impediment, a filter that impoverishes rather than enriches musical practice. Over the past twenty-five years, however, work in such diverse fields as linguistics, film studies, literary theory, popular music studies, rhetoric, sociology, ethnomusicology, and historical musicology has pointed a way past this normative conception of genre, advancing in its place a more flexible, pragmatic understanding of the concept.¹¹ As literary theorist Wai-Chee Dimock has observed, within this new paradigm genres no longer refer to “taxonomic classes of equal solidity” but to “fields at once emerging and ephemeral, defined over and over again by new entries that are being produced” (2007, 1379). A genre, by this account, is not to be construed as a stable class of objects, defined by possession of some discrete set of fixed characteristics. Rather, it is to be understood as a dynamic ensemble of correlations, linking together a variety of material, institutional, social, and symbolic resources: repertoires, performance practices, distinctive formal and stylistic traits, aesthetic discourses, forms of self-presentation, institutions, specific modes of technological mediation, social identities, and so forth. These correlations in turn give rise to an array of assumptions, behaviors, and competences, which taken together orient the (individual) actions and (social) interactions of different “art world” participants: composers, performers, publishers, audiences, critics, music industry personnel, arts administrators, and music scholars (among others).¹² It is by virtue of the frameworks that

10 An example of the latter may be seen in the implicit racial coding of experimental music. As George Lewis observes, the habitual assumption of experimental music’s whiteness has led countless critics and scholars to exclude African-Americans and other people of color from historical and critical accounts of the genre (2008, xii–xiii). Along similar lines, Karl Hagstrom Miller (2010) has examined how the racial coding of hillbilly and blues genres in the first half of the twentieth century materially affected musicians’ careers, severely restricting the range of professional opportunities available to them.

11 See, for instance, Fowler 1982; Miller 1984; Kallberg 1988; Briggs and Bauman 1992; Negus 1999; Toynbee 2000; Brackett 2005; Dimock 2007; Holt 2007; Frow 2008; Kronengold 2008; Sparling 2008; and Born 2010.

12 On the notion of art worlds, see Becker 1984.

genres furnish that composers are able to produce music that is likely to produce an intended effect upon targeted audiences, performers can give a stylistically appropriate account of a piece, concert organizers know what works to program for which venue, record stores (real and virtual) know how to catalog their merchandise, critics are capable of recognizing which standards to apply in evaluating a concert or recording, and listeners know what to expect of a given work or performance.

Reconceptualizing genre along these lines has a number of distinct advantages, not the least of which is that it breaks free of the habit of representing the relation between texts and genres as one of membership in a discrete, bounded class. As an ensemble of correlations, a genre is not so much a *group* as a *grouping*, the gerund ending calling attention to the fact that it is something that must be continually produced and reproduced. Genres, in other words, result from acts of assemblage, acts performed by specific agents in specific social and institutional settings.¹³ One consequence of this is a certain fluidity in the classification of individual musical texts. Depending on who is doing the classifying, and under what circumstances, the same song or work may be brought into a relation with a variety of other songs or works and, in this way, with a variety of distinct genres (Brackett 2005, 76). Differences in taste, interest, education, identification, aesthetic ideology, and social position influence not only how individual genres are conceived but also how the broader field of musical genres is imagined, giving rise to divergent maps of this field and divergent ways of siting texts within

13 The discussion of genre that follows is informed in broad outlines by the work of actor-network theorists like Michel Callon (1987), Bruno Latour (1987, 2007), John Law (1992, 2004), and Annemarie Mol (2002), but it is above all inspired by the application of ANT to the field of experimental music in Piekut 2011. The notion of the actor network, as outlined in Callon 1987, conceives the social construction of a fact or object as involving the linking together of “heterogeneous elements, animate and inanimate” into an assemblage or network, whose success depends on “the solidity and the longevity of [these] heterogeneous associations” (93). Such networks are inherently unstable, however, inasmuch as each constituent element is also an actor, who “could at any moment redefine their identity and mutual relationships in some new way” (93). In other words, each actor—a term that encompasses both human and nonhuman participants—is perfectly capable of refusing the role they have been conscripted to perform within the network.

Particularly notable is the performative character of actor networks. While the notion of performativity has a well-established pedigree in research on social identity and self-fashioning—as in the work of Judith Butler (1990) on gender identity and Goffman (1959) on the presentation of the self—a key contribution of actor-network theorists such as Callon, Latour, Mol, and Law has been to extend

this notion to phenomena customarily regarded as “objective,” such as scientific facts, technologies, or physical objects. Thus, Mol, in her 2002 ethnographic study of the diagnosis and treatment of atherosclerosis, points out that the disease as identified under the microscope in a hospital’s pathology department is not identical to the disease as diagnosed by means of an examination in an outpatient clinic, and that neither of these is identical to the disease as targeted in the course of surgical treatment. Since each of these varied practices constructs a different network of people, objects, and technologies, they each give rise to distinct objects—all bearing the same name, however—whose coordination involves considerable collective effort. Similar observations may be made with regard to music: a genre as enacted through the programming decisions of a concert organizer is not the same as the genre as enacted by a journalist in the course of writing an article, and neither of these are the same as the genre as enacted by musicians in the act of producing a composition or performance. Each of these actions produces a different genre by performing it through different practices. And, as is the case with atherosclerosis, the problem then becomes one of how the diverse set of objects designated by the same signifier (*atherosclerosis*, *genre X*) are to be brought into alignment with one another, if they are capable of being brought into alignment at all.

its strange and ever-shifting topography. The multiplicity of institutional settings in which a piece of music may be heard likewise encourages discrepancies in its classification. The slow movement to Mozart's Piano Concerto no. 21 in C major K. 467, for instance, may be understood to participate in a variety of genres depending on whether it is encountered as part of a concerto competition, a concert of orchestral music, a historical anthology of late-eighteenth-century music, the soundtrack to the film *Elvira Madigan*, or the waiting room of a doctor's office. Whether the movement is heard as a concerto, a piece of symphonic music, an exemplar of Viennese classicism, a bit of film music, or easy listening will vary with respect to the context in which it occurs—or, more precisely, with respect to the groupings tacitly carried out by the acts of performance, programming, anthologizing, scoring, or broadcasting that serve to locate the movement within these contrasting milieus.

Similar discrepancies result from the fact that the groupings designated by genre labels vary considerably in scale. At one limit are those broad and indistinct categories that divide the musical field into a small number of agonistically defined camps: “art” versus “popular” music, “Western” versus “non-Western,” “old” versus “new.” At the other limit are the manifold genres, subgenres, and sub-subgenres that proliferate in response to the demands of artistic and social distinction. Between these two extremes lay an indeterminate number of other strata, of varying degrees of generality and specificity. What is crucial to observe about this stratification of generic space is that the different-sized groupings it allows for are seldom regarded as mutually exclusive but are typically imagined in the form of a nested hierarchy. Thus, the same piece or song may be subsumed by a fairly wide-reaching and nonspecific metagenre (for instance, “rock music”) at the same time as it participates in a fairly narrow and highly specified subgenre (such as “straight-edge,” “glam,” or “math rock”). While there may very well be disagreement over which level of classification is most appropriate for an adequate understanding of a work, such dissensus does not imply that a grouping at one level necessarily precludes groupings at other possible levels. To say that the “Blue Danube Waltz,” the “Charleston,” and Donna Summer’s “Love to Love You Baby” all participate in the metagenre of “dance music” may say very little about the peculiarities of these three pieces of music, but this does not invalidate such a grouping in principle. Nor would the employment of narrower categories—categories that would better reflect these three pieces’ specificities by pulling them apart rather than lumping them together—necessarily call the broader metacategory into question. Broad and narrow categorizations can coexist, even if this coexistence is marked by friction.

Acknowledging that the groupings actors fashion are inherently variable is not, however, to deny the considerable overlap or agreement that exists among different individuals. Differences in terms of taste, education, and patterns of socialization are not absolute but relative, a fact that ensures a

degree of consensus regarding the makeup of genres and the kinds of correlations they are thought to entail. Conversely, recognizing the instability of genre classifications does not amount to asserting that individuals possess absolute license in the groupings they are able to perform.¹⁴ The fact that such groupings must be continually enacted and reenacted—no matter how stable, secure, or familiar they may appear—means that their legitimacy depends on how many people recognize them, take them up, and thereby reproduce the specific configuration of texts and contexts that they establish. And this in turn depends upon the material, discursive, institutional, and symbolic resources enlisted to perpetuate a given grouping. On the one hand, the authority accorded certain institutions and individuals transfers over to the groupings they perform, with the categories proposed by actors in possession of substantial “symbolic capital” often given more weight than those proposed by actors bereft of such capital. On the other hand, a particular configuration of musical texts will attain a durability that other, competing configurations lack to the extent that it manages to imprint itself upon those objects, discourses, equipment, and organizations that, along with their human counterparts, populate an art world. “Thoughts are cheap but they don’t last long, and speech lasts very little longer” sociologist John Law observes. “But when we start to perform relations—and in particular when we embody them in inanimate materials such as texts and buildings—they may last longer” (1992, 387). It is by means of this sort of material, institutional, and discursive inscription that certain groupings take on the appearance of substantial, objective, even “natural” entities.¹⁵ But while such inscriptions may help reify certain genres, encouraging the tendency to view them as ostensive *groups* rather than as performative *groupings*, this is only because it creates conditions conducive for their subsequent appropriation by others—that is, for their continual enactment and reenactment. And it is this continual reenactment, not the mere fact of material or institutional embodiment, which is crucial for the perpetuation of a given genre. As Bruno Latour notes, “if you stop making and remaking groups, you stop having groups” (2007, 35). The

¹⁴ Even if there is in principle no limit on the individual’s ability to associate texts and contexts, there is for the same reason no limit on the ability of others to disregard groupings they deem irrelevant or overly idiosyncratic. Agency cuts both ways. Acts of genre classification, by mobilizing acquired musical competences, are what allow individuals to reap whatever dividends derive from making themselves appear competent in the eyes of others. But by the same token, such acts always threaten to have the opposite effect, of making individuals appear incompetent, in the event the groupings they enact should deviate too greatly from those maintained by others. As much as anything, it is these competing incentives—the promise of symbolic benefit that comes from trafficking in established groupings and the risk of symbolic sanction that comes

from eschewing them—that encourages a certain degree of consensus in the categories that members of a given art world elaborate.

¹⁵ This is clearly the case with regard to the stablest of groupings: canons. To be successfully imposed, a canon requires some form of material embodiment to ensure its reproduction through space and time. This point is implicitly made in Kerman 1983, which emphasizes the role of written texts and recordings in the transmission of canons. Likewise, Katherine Bergeron’s description of the names of great composers that line the ceiling of Paine Concert Hall at Harvard University vividly demonstrates how such inscriptions are put to work in practice (1992, 1).

partitioning of the musical field given material form in the printed pages of a textbook, in the sequence of songs on a radio station playlist, or in the layout of a record store remains inert as long as it fails to be taken up by readers, listeners, and consumers in turn.

If it is true that correlations between texts (and between texts and contexts) are continually being asserted, it is no less true that such performative acts of grouping are inevitably accompanied by their opposite, by an implicit contrast with—or denial of—other possible groupings. The formation of any group, as Latour observes, necessarily involves the formation of “antigroups” (2007, 31–32). Genres, as noted above, are defined in relational terms, as much by what they are not as by what they are. The heterogeneous correlations that, when taken together, define a genre acquire significance not only with respect to one another but also with respect to other correlations that could have been made in their place for them but were not. Peculiarities in terms of style, aesthetic discourse, consumption patterns, performance practices, technical mediation, distribution channels, and audience demographics are peculiar precisely because they establish a significant difference with respect to other possible styles, aesthetic discourses, consumption patterns, and so forth. Consider, for instance, the use of “found sound” in *musique concrète*. This practice, a defining feature of the genre, is not meaningful in itself. But neither does its significance derive wholly from the position it occupies within the constellation of musical, aesthetic, technological, and institutional resources whose interconnection constitute *musique concrète* as a distinct (and distinctive) genre of electroacoustic music. Rather, its significance derives as much from its contrast with other possible means of generating sound, most notably those obtained by synthetic means, the distinguishing mark of *musique concrète*’s principal rival during its formative years, *elektronische Musik*.

This highlights another factor that influences which groupings are likely to stabilize and win widespread acceptance, and which are unlikely to do so. Apart from the material, discursive, and institutional resources whose support certain genres are able to enlist, those assemblages whose elements occupy homologous positions in their respective domains are more likely to cohere than those that do not. It is not just the quantity of the resources a grouping is able to command, but their perceived quality. The texts and contexts conjoined within a genre reinforce one another inasmuch as they all seem to belong to the same “register.”¹⁶ Otherwise tensions may emerge that compromise the stability of the assemblage. It is precisely this sort of disjunction, for instance, that critiques of institutionalized modernism tend to exploit: the perceived “dissonance” between the oppositional pose associated with modernism, on the one hand, and the “establishment” backing that particular modernist genres (in particular academic serialism) have enjoyed, on the

16 On the notion of register, see Long 2008, esp. chap. 1.

other, leave it vulnerable to charges of hypocrisy, or worse. A similar logic governs accusations of “selling out” in certain forms of popular music. Insofar as genres like indie rock are defined in large measure by their opposition to a putative mainstream (say, commercial Top Forty), the moment a band affiliated with the genre signs with a major label, a dissonant element is introduced into the ensemble of correlations that comprise this particular genre.¹⁷ This dissonance may be addressed in a number of ways (without, however, being necessarily resolved): by the ejection of the offending band from the genre; by an adjustment in the genre’s aesthetic discourse to accommodate the breach; by the mobilization of countervailing resources to justify the band’s actions and thus its continuing inclusion in the genre; or by the abandonment of the genre by some portion of its audience. What is vital to note is that the identification of some discordant node (“establishment” support, major labels) within the network of relations that constitutes a genre implies the existence of some alternative (nontraditional funding sources, independent labels), an alternative that would presumably accord better with the other nodes precisely on account of its homology with them.

The revised conception of genre that I have outlined here has a number of implications for the analysis and interpretation of contemporary music. Of these one of the most important involves the way in which the groupings performed in acts of genre classification frame musical texts.¹⁸ By relating a piece of music with one set of texts and not some other, individuals (including analysts) make an implicit judgment regarding what kinds of knowledge are relevant for “correctly” understanding the work in question, which formal and stylistic features are significant and merit attention and which may be safely disregarded, and what sort of analytical metalanguage is appropriate for representing musical events. In short, by aligning a piece of music with all those works that are gathered together under a particular genre heading, one assumes that the interpretive schemata developed in response to the latter will apply equally to the former. By itself, this observation perhaps goes without saying. Genre’s role in framing texts—musical or otherwise—is well established. But once genre is conceived as something mutable, relational, and above all enacted, then the number of interpretive schemata that can be legitimately mobilized to make sense of a given text multiplies. Granted, certain generic categories and groupings will be so thoroughly stabilized, their

¹⁷ Consider, for instance, the fairly standard description of “selling out” given in Thornton 1996: “Within club under-grounds, it seems to me that ‘to sell’ means ‘to betray’ and ‘selling out’ refers to the process by which artists or songs sell beyond their initial market which, in turn, loses its sense of possession, exclusive ownership and familiar belonging. In other words, ‘selling out’ means selling to outsiders” (124). Notice that in this account the “betrayal” committed by artists accused of selling out involves two interlinked processes: their dissociation from a previous set of correla-

tions (a particular audience, a niche market, a non- or anti-commercial ethos) and their subsequent association with a new, antagonistically defined set of correlations (a larger audience, a mass market, a new-found interest in commercial success). For a useful critique of the discourse of “selling out,” see Hesmondhalgh 1999.

¹⁸ The notion of framing developed here is informed by Goffman 1974. For an application to genre theory, see Frow 2008, 103–9.

legitimacy so widely recognized, that there is no longer any dispute as to whether a given piece belongs in its ranks. In cases like these, the number of frames deemed valid for a “competent” interpretation narrows considerably. Who, after all, would deny that Beethoven’s early works are to be understood as tokens of the Viennese classical style, whose codes and conventions should therefore govern their analysis? But this sort of stability in generic groupings is decidedly not the norm for post-1945 music, whose “privileged contexts” are still very much in flux.¹⁹ If nothing else, the number of discrepant categories listed in Figure 1 attest that the partitioning of this field, far from being a settled matter, remains as yet unresolved, still subject to revision, contest, and negotiation. A number of factors explain the volatility of genre categories within the field of contemporary art music. In part it is a product of the weak institutional position that this particular formation occupies with respect to the broader field of Western art music (which is not to deny the success avant-garde and experimental composers have had in establishing an alternative infrastructure to support the production, propagation, and reception of their music; see Born 1995). The relatively marginal position of new music within key art music institutions—the concert hall, music history curricula, music pedagogies—means that the resources available to stabilize certain formations are not nearly as formidable as those that provide the secure foundation for more entrenched groupings, such as that which falls under the heading of the “canon.” More important for the continuing instability of genre categories within this repertory is their furious denial within the aesthetic discourse of new music, which takes it as an article of faith that the only relevant context for comprehending a composition is furnished by the composition itself. As Charles Wilson (2004) has suggested, the pressure placed on composers to distinguish both themselves and their works from rivals within this particular market of symbolic goods means that efforts at defining stable groupings are perennially undermined. And yet this unceasing labor of position taking serves at one and the same time as a catalyst for further group formation. When a composer such as Iannis Xenakis proposes stochastic music as an alternative to serialism, or when Michael Nyman (1974) sets Anglo-American experimentalism in opposition to the European avant-garde, the articulation of difference effectively outlines a broader field of musical activity—that of “new” or “contemporary” music—that is both the site of this internecine struggle and the object over which various parties contend.

To understand how the reconceptualization of genre advanced above might prove useful for the analysis and interpretation of contemporary art music, the sections that follow examine Gérard Grisey’s *Les espaces acoustiques* in light of the various groupings with which it may be aligned, and the different constructions of the cycle that these that these groupings afford. It should

¹⁹ The notion of privileged context is borrowed from Korsyn 1999.

be noted, however, that undertaking such an analysis of Grisey's work—one that accounts for the multiple generic contexts in which it may participate—necessarily involves a change in orientation. For once our attention turns toward a particular piece of music and away from genre, the fluid and provisional character of the latter will inevitably recede, to the point where it threatens to disappear from our field of vision entirely. Genre in these circumstances ceases to be what Latour refers to as a “matter of concern,” an entity whose status is unsettled and therefore the object of ongoing controversy, and comes to resemble a “matter of fact,” an entity whose status is taken as given.²⁰ It is the identity of the work that now becomes the principal matter of concern, as one seeks to determine whether it is best considered a piece of classical music, easy listening, or something else altogether. Genre here assumes the character of a resource that is summoned to help answer the question, What kind of thing is this? And, as John Frow has observed, this is a necessary preliminary to answering another, more crucial question: What is it that's going on here? (2008, 100).

But if it is generally the case that genres acquire a certain degree of fixity and coherence the moment they are recruited for the task of establishing the identity of an individual work, it is equally the case that such fixity and coherence are more apparent than real. It is not just that at any moment the particular construction of the genre invoked in connection to a piece of music may itself be called into question, transformed from a matter of fact back into a matter of concern (though this may certainly occur). It is also that the act of tying a work to the ensemble of texts and contexts that defines a genre does not leave this genre unchanged. As soon as we hear a piece as belonging to a larger group, we perform an act of grouping. Furthermore, the varied attributes this piece is thought to instantiate—be these stylistic, aesthetic, institutional, or social—refashion the genre in their image, even as they are brought into alignment with the heterogeneous correlations that constitute the genre. In the case of Grisey's *Les espaces acoustiques*, its close identification with spectralism frames the cycle, throwing certain of its characteristics into relief while denying the significance of others. But the cycle also frames spectralism, throwing certain characteristics of this movement into relief while denying the significance of others. The same can be said of other genres with which Grisey's music might be brought into relation. Were *Les espaces acoustiques* to be construed in more general terms, as a representative of the art music tradition as a whole, this would require that the meta-genre be reconfigured so as to better accommodate the numerous transgressions the cycle commits against its norms. If this reciprocal action is not always readily apparent, it is because our attentions and interests are in this

²⁰ On matters of fact versus matters of concern, see Latour 2007, 87–120.

particular instance invested in one side of this relation (the work) to the detriment of the other (the genre).

4.

Prior to exploring how *Les espaces acoustiques* relates to spectralism—not to mention how it relates to other, broader generic groupings—it is first of all necessary to address the question of what, exactly, spectralism is. There already exists a small but substantial literature on this topic. Rather than add to the growing mass of texts describing the movement's origins, aims, and distinguishing features, let us instead see what others have had to say.

"The musical school referred to as 'Spectral Music,' was begun in France in the early seventies" (Fineberg 2000, 1), founded by "a group of . . . composers born in the 1940s whose best-known members are [Gérard] Grisey, Tristan Murail, Michäel Levinas and Hugues Dufourt" (Hasegawa 2009, 349). All participated in *l'Itinéraire*, an "ensemble formed in 1973 by students in Olivier Messiaen's class at the Paris Conservatory" (Wilson 1989, 55), which was "in part responsible for the diffusion" of spectral music (Anderson 1989, 20). Apart from their former teacher, major influences included "the music of Ligeti (*Atmosphères*, *Lontano*), Xenakis (*Metastasis*, *Pithoprakta*), the drawn-out works of the American La Monte Young, the Stockhausen of *Stimmung*, [and] even the mythic Scelsi" (Sedes 2002, 27)—though some writers prefer to view the movement as part of a longer, "cumulative development . . . rooted in the French interest in perception and continuous with French values" (Pasler 2008, 82). Or, as Theo Hirsbrunner puts it, spectralism participates in "a tradition that can be traced back to Claude Debussy . . . , a typically French tradition of sonic lushness [Klangsinnlichkeit]" (2001, 5).

Musically, spectralism is noted for "us[ing] the acoustic properties of sound itself (or sound spectra) as the basis of its compositional material" (Anderson 2001, 166). This emphasis on sound was partly "a reaction against the abstraction of serial music" (Hasegawa 2009, 349), which was accused of having "projected onto sonic reality inexorable grids" (Murail 2004, 15). But the "return to sound" (Malherbe 1989, 47) or "return to musical evidence" (Condé 1978) effected by spectralism also reflected the fact that the approach to music adopted by Grisey, Murail, and their colleagues was "deeply post-electronic" (Fineberg 2008, 32). That is, their "timbral manipulations [were] based on more than empirical *trouvailles*," being grounded in a "knowledge of acoustics, psychoacoustics, and the mathematical models [that have been developed] to describe sound" (32). Connected with this was the spectralists' "exploration, within an instrumental context, of techniques derived from the analogue electronic studio" (Anderson 2001, 167), an exploration later expanded to incorporate digital and computer technologies as well. Perhaps "the most characteristic" of these techniques was instrumental synthesis, which "mimics the electronic music technique of additive synthesis, but replaces

pure sine tones with the complex sounds of real instruments” (Hasegawa 2009, 349–50). But this does not exhaust the full range of technological processes emulated in spectral music. As Grisey himself noted, “To different types of spectral writing correspond different treatments borrowed from electronic music techniques,” treatments which include “filtering, reverberation, and frequency modulation” (2008, 109).

The series of quotations that make up this brief sketch of spectral music already enact a variety of groupings, some explicit, others less so, some adhering to established musical categories, others cutting across familiar lines of demarcation. A number of criteria are invoked to determine what is to be incorporated into the network of elements that comprise “spectral music” and what is to be omitted. These include nationality (French), generational cohort (birth date after 1945), interpersonal and professional ties (involvement in *l'Itinéraire*), compositional technique (use of electroacoustic models), and aesthetic orientation (the vaunted “return to sound”). Depending on the weight attached to each of these criteria, and how they are combined, our conception of what constitutes spectral music will turn out differently. Other constructions of the category “spectral music” might eliminate some of these grouping principles altogether; for instance, dismissing nationality as a pertinent factor produces a more expansive definition of spectralism, one that accounts for its “Romanian” and “North American” variants.²¹ Conversely, one might single out one of these ordering principles as foundational, deeming it to be of greater import than all the others. A case in point is Joshua Fineberg’s remark that the “particularity and innovation” of spectralism “was not linked to its Frenchness” but to a more generalized attitude, namely, a belief that “what music ultimately is about is the transformation of sound” (2008, 32–33). For Fineberg it is possession of this attitude—and not some ostensibly contingent attribute like nationality—that is key to distinguishing a spectral composer from a nonspectral composer, a spectral work from a nonspectral work.

Also to be noted is the relational quality of the various groupings performed over the course of this sketch. Defining what kind of music spectral music is entails defining how it connects (or does not connect) to other kinds of music. Hence, it is variously described as part of a long-standing French tradition; as influenced by Messiaen, Ligeti, Scelsi, and other “proto-spectral” composers; as drawing upon electroacoustic music; or as opposed to serialism. Among the numerous relations invoked in the process of defining spectral music, two merit particular consideration. The first involves its relation to electroacoustic music. Noting that certain techniques developed by Grisey, Murail, and other spectralists mimic technological models presupposes a

²¹ On Romanian spectralism, see Surianu 2000 and Teodorescu-Ciocanea 2003; on North American spectralism, see Wannamaker 2008.

sharp division between instrumental music, on the one hand, and electro-acoustic music, on the other. While this particular partitioning of the musical field treats difference in sound production as foundational, as if it were the only distinction that truly matters, it is far from the only significant point of contrast. No less than any other genre, these overarching categories each comprise a heterogeneous array of material, symbolic, social, and institutional elements. This means that the mobilization of the electronic/instrumental distinction for the purpose of refining our understanding of what spectral music is sets in motion a whole host of correlated distinctions—distinctions that go beyond whether sounds are produced by conventional mechanical instruments or by loudspeakers, to encompass differences in audience makeup, institutional setting, division of musical labor, standards of aesthetic evaluation, musical ontology, and so forth. How we perceive the electronic models emulated in spectral music, and what significance we attach to them, depends as much on such apparently secondary distinctions as it does on the central distinction drawn between “acoustic” and “electroacoustic” methods of sound generation.

But if the citation of technological models plays on a tacit opposition that sets instrumental and electroacoustic musics against one another, the incorporation of instrumental music’s “other” in spectral compositions effects a number of significant transformations in each member of this binary pair. Consider, for instance, the technique of instrumental synthesis. By far the most famous instance of this technique—and no doubt the most famous passage in the spectral literature—comes at the opening of *Partiels*, the third piece of *Les espaces acoustiques* (see Example 1). The trombone plays an E2, reinforced an octave below by repeated attacks on the double bass. Other instruments within the eighteen-part ensemble then enter, with each instrument “doubling” the frequency of some partial of the trombone’s spectrum. But the spectral mimicry does not end there, as the different parts of the ensemble approximate in addition the loudness, order of entry, and duration of the partials to which they correspond. The result is one of the “liminal” effects that Grisey prized, an object that is not quite a timbre but not quite a harmony either. The ambiguous status of this sonority is in no small part due to the alterations that this technique effects in both the electronic model (additive synthesis) and the instrumental medium in which this model is realized. On the one hand, the substitution of the complex spectra of orchestral instruments for sine waves precludes the kind of seamless fusion that additive synthesis affords. So, too, do various sources of human “error,” including inaccuracies in microtonal inflection, discrepancies in the timing and duration of entries, and the temporal distension the spectrum undergoes as a result of its realization by human performers. On the other hand, simulating the fusion of partials into a single, cohesive sound requires the suppression of certain traits characteristic of conventional instrumental timbres: attacks are attenuated, instruments are made to play notes outside the equal-

Example 1. *Partiels, opening*

tempered scale, and instruments possessing too distinctive a timbre (like the oboe) are omitted from the ensemble altogether.²² In this way each term of the electronic/instrumental binarism is defamiliarized, passing through the distorting lens of its opposite number. Yet the reciprocal defamiliarization of the instrumental by the electronic (and vice versa) is itself predicated upon a founding act of distinction, one that defines each of these two types of music in terms of their absolute, categorical difference from one another.

The second major opposition invoked in standard accounts of spectral music pits it against serialism. Composers identified with the movement lodged a number of complaints against their serial colleagues, but two in particular are crucial to spectralism's self-conception. The first has to do with serialism's purported disregard for the specificity of different sounds, its tendency to treat all and sundry in the same reductive fashion. The disarticulation of sound into a set of discrete, abstract, and artificial parameters, which are then arbitrarily superimposed, not only ignores acoustical realities but also robs the sonic stuff of music of its richness and complexity. By contrast, spectral composers set out to cultivate a greater sensitivity toward the material dimensions of music, a stance that assumes the weight of a quasi-ethical obligation in the writings of Grisey: "To play, no longer with notes, but with the nature of sound itself—I say 'play' and not 'dominate'—supposes the recognition of the different races and ethnicities of sounds, and a respect for their cultures" (2008, 46). A second, related way in which spectralism distinguished itself from its serial forebears involves the latter's alleged reification of sound. Serial composers approached the notes in the score as if they were stable, solid objects, to be put together and taken apart like so many building blocks. In so doing, they mistook notational symbols for the phenomena they represented. On this point, too, spectralism offered a marked contrast with serial technique, viewing sound as something inherently fluid and dynamic. What spectrographs and other technologies of acoustic analysis demonstrate, Murail observed, is that "every sound is essentially variable," changing its form and substance "not only from one iteration to another, of course, but also within its own duration." For this reason it is necessary to cease conceiving sound "in terms of 'parameters' (timbre, pitch, intensity, duration)," as serialism had done, and instead imagine it "as a field of forces, each force possessing its own evolution" (2004, 12).²³

22 Hurel 1991, 265, enumerates some of the changes that instrumental synthesis imposes upon orchestration.

23 While these are the most clearly drawn points of comparison between spectralism and serialism, it is necessary to bear in mind that they are scarcely the only ones in play. As was the case with the instrumental/electroacoustic opposition discussed above, the spectralism/serialism opposition extends beyond musical or aesthetic differences narrowly construed to encompass distinctions typically bracketed out of analytical consideration on account of their

"extramusical" (i.e., social) character. Differences in institutional support, audience, rhetoric, the kinds of imaginary identifications the two movements afford—these and other correlated factors at once frame and are in turn framed by the "purely" musical and/or aesthetic differences that serve to distinguish the two movements. This is clearly seen in Grisey's call to respect the different "races and ethnicities" of sound, which mobilizes a political imperative—the *droit à la différence* advocated by certain factions of the post-1968 French left—and uses it to frame a particular

More important for the present discussion than the particulars of spectralism's polemic with serialism is the conceptual space that this antagonistic relationship delineates. As already observed in connection to composers' position-takings, such rivalries not only draw a clear line of demarcation between opposing aesthetic camps but also tacitly indicate the participation of both parties in a broader field of shared concerns. "Struggle," as Pierre Bourdieu observes, "presupposes an agreement among the antagonists on what merits being struggled over" (2002, 115). Spectralism, by vocally denouncing serialism and seeking to counter its (allegedly) pernicious influence on contemporary composition, thereby announced its commitment to the very milieu where this influence held sway—what we may provisionally dub the domain of "avant-garde music." Furthermore, this broad generic category is itself locked in an antagonistic relation with another, equally broad category, what is variously referred to as "classic-romantic music," the "canon," or the "standard repertoire." In this regard it is worth recalling that appellations like *avant-garde*, *new*, and *contemporary* implicitly define the musics they designate in terms of their opposition to other musics, those that are deemed rear guard, old, or antiquated. Here, too, the dichotomous relation between different kinds of music presupposes the involvement of both within an even broader metagenre: what in German goes by the name of E-Musik, in French by the name of "musique savante," and in English by the name "art" or "serious" music.²⁴

Figure 2 depicts this series of alternating oppositions and inclusions. What is vital to observe is that each successive layer in this series constitutes a different way of grouping *Les espaces acoustiques*, a different set of texts and contexts that Grisey's music may be brought into relation with. As such, each layer suggests a different way of framing the cycle in the course of listening

aesthetic imperative. For more on the social and political coding of spectralism's aesthetic imaginary, see Drott 2009. For a complementary reading of the relations between spectralism and serialism, see Goldman 2010.

24 If this seems too tidy or schematic a representation of the musical field, it is important to bear in mind that any map of this kind will be as fluid and provisional as the individual genres that it encompasses. After all, such maps are nothing more than higher-order groupings of other groupings (i.e., genres). Much as a genre will vary according to which set of texts and contexts it ties together, and which other set of texts and contexts it defines itself against, so too will the arrangement of genres into families of differing scales vary according to what other kinds of music a particular genre is aligned with and/or distinguished from in any given enactment. If, for example, our point of departure is an antagonism other than that which sets spectralism against serialism, then our picture of musical space shifts

accordingly. Consider Murail's contention that rock has been more attentive to the changes wrought by new technologies than contemporary classical music. He admonishes composers for having failed to formulate "concepts that will allow the new sonic reality that faces us to be organized," noting ominously that should composers choose to ignore this historic responsibility, "others will do it for us." He then adds by way of warning that "the spectacular development of synthesizers and electronic sound more generally owes more to Pink Floyd than to Stockhausen" (2004, 13). Here, the agonistic relation that emerges between contemporary classical music and rock defines a different field of shared concern than that which is articulated by the spectralism/serialism opposition. It is not "contemporary music" but what we might give the somewhat cumbersome title of "technologically mediated music" that is the object over which the two genres contend.

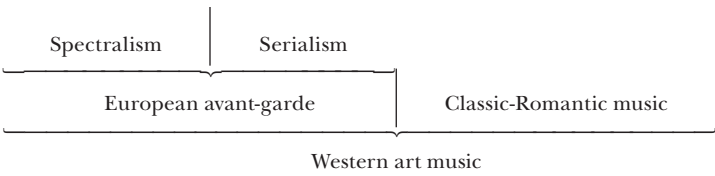


Figure 2. Field of genre oppositions

to, analyzing, or interpreting it.²⁵ At the most specific level, the pieces that compose *Les espaces acoustiques* may be heard as specimens of the category “spectral music,” a framing that among other things draws attention to the music’s simulation of electronic effects, the establishment of structural polarities between harmonic and inharmonic sonorities, the prominence attached to process in elaborating the music’s form, the use of spectral models, and the presence of elements largely banished from serial and postserial music (consonant sonorities, periodic rhythms). At an intermediate level of generality, the cycle may be heard as a specimen of the category “avant-garde” music, a framing that instead emphasizes such traits as the music’s incorporation of dissonant, nontonal, and/or microtonal sound materials (all the way up to and including phenomena conventionally classed as noise); the emphasis placed on texture, timbre, and other “secondary” parameters at the expense of melody, rhythmic figuration, and other “primary” parameters; the intermittent employment of extended instrumental techniques; and the eschewal of traditional formal schemes. Finally, at the broadest and most general level, *Les espaces acoustiques* may be heard as a specimen of the category “Western art music,” a framing that, in bringing the cycle into closer relation with works drawn from the standard repertory, highlights its various points of contact with this body of music: the prevalence of standard orchestral instruments, the residue of performance practices typically associated with these instruments, the relatively limited use of amplification and other forms of overt technological manipulation, the customary division of labor between composer and performer, and the occasional appearance of sonorities, rhythmic motifs, and linear patterns reminiscent of classic and romantic music. (Also of note here are the absences that align this work with “Western art music” as opposed to other, alternative metagenres, like jazz or pop: nowhere

²⁵ One may take this observation a step further and say that the groupings thus enacted do not produce distinct perspectives on the same object as much as produce distinct objects. Depending on what it is associated with, *Les espaces acoustiques* may be a number of different things: a piece of spectral music, a piece of avant-garde music, a piece of Western art music. Each of these has (among other things) its own peculiar ontology and its own form of temporality. As a piece of Western art music, for instance,

Grisey’s work is accorded a historicity and a potential to persist through time usually lacking with regard to avant-garde music, whose temporality, in contrast, is defined in terms of transience rather than endurance. On the multiplicity of the object, and the various ontologies this implies, see Mol 2002. For illuminating discussions of the temporality of different forms of music, see Straw 1991 and Born 2010.

to be found in *Les espaces acoustiques* are such elements as vocals, improvised solos, rhythm sections, and verse-chorus structures.)

That any of these generic contexts has the potential to be mobilized in listening to and analyzing *Les espaces acoustiques* does not, of course, mean that in any given instance all or even most of them will. Again, disparities in taste, education, aesthetic orientation, ideology, and identity play a role in deciding which grouping (or combination thereof) is performed in connection to this or any other piece of music. These same disparities likewise influence the value accorded to different ways of framing the work and, concomitantly, the interpretations to which they give rise. Given the close association of genres with social categories defined in terms of race, class, gender, age, and/or nationality, individuals will often value those musics with which they identify strongly. Furthermore, greater importance will likely be attached to those competences that individuals have invested significant time and effort in acquiring, an assessment that carries over to the kind of understanding that such competences make available. Listeners conversant in the music of Grisey, Murail, and other spectral composers will likely be inclined to place greater stress on hearing the music in its “own terms” and will be just as likely to be dismissive of interpretations that fail to do so. Conversely, listeners lacking such familiarity, but steeped in the Western art music tradition nonetheless, will evidently be predisposed to hear such music in terms of its departures from the norms of this metagenre.

In acknowledging such disparities, however, it is important not to exaggerate them or treat them as absolutes. If it is true that individuals are likely to attach greater weight to those genres with which they identify closely, it is no less true that such imaginary musical identifications are plural, not singular, reflecting the variety of subject positions and social roles individuals adopt in the course of everyday life. Likewise, while time and attention may indeed be limited resources, constraining the range of individuals’ musical investments, they are not so limited as to preclude acquisition of competence in multiple genres. On the contrary, as recent work in the sociology of culture has demonstrated, individuals more often than not participate in a variety of taste cultures.²⁶ Thus, the surfeit of groupings enacted in connection with *Les espaces acoustiques*—or in connection to any other piece, for that matter—is matched by the surfeit of competences that individuals can call upon in making sense of the music. Every event, every gesture, every process that unfolds over the course of the cycle may be related to a variety of generic contexts and possesses, as a result, an assortment of overlapping and at times divergent connotations.

To illustrate how the interaction of these different groupings color our perception of *Les espaces acoustiques*, consider the climactic passage of the first piece, *Prologue* for solo viola. As is the case with the other works that make up

²⁶ See Peterson and Simkus 1992, Lahire 2004, and Ollivier 2008.

Gérard Grisey
PROLOGUE
pour alto seul

Example 2. *Prologue*, opening

the cycle, the form of *Prologue* involves a gradual drift back and forth between two opposed poles.²⁷ At one end of this continuum are passages in which periodic rhythms and sonorities derived from harmonic spectra predominate, while at the other end are passages where aperiodic rhythms and sonorities derived from inharmonic spectra or noise come to the fore. (In subsequent works in the cycle these points of large-scale rhythmic and harmonic contrast are supplemented by a further opposition, which sets fused, homogeneous textures against more complex, stratified ones.) Grisey likens this steady movement from stability to instability and back again to the cycle of respiration, with motion away from the initial “zone of repose” toward noise representing inhalation, and motion in the opposite direction representing exhalation. In the course of *Prologue*, only one full cycle of respiration is completed. The piece opens with the viola playing a melodic pattern whose pitches are drawn from the spectrum of an unheard fundamental E1 (see Example 2), with pitches foreign to this harmonic spectrum progressively introduced as the piece continues. The accumulation of these inharmonic elements leads gradually to a saturation of pitch space. The distortion of the initial harmonic spectrum culminates with the viola tipping over into a kind of simulated white noise, reminiscent of feedback or distortion. The process then reverses, the noise abates, and the viola reenters the orbit of the E1’s harmonic series. The end of this large-scale “respiration” coincides with the opening of the second work of *Les espaces acoustiques*, *Périodes* for seven instruments. Signaling the attainment of a temporary point of rest at the beginning of *Périodes* is the entry of the double bass playing a low E1, which, despite its role in generating the pitch material of the outer sections of *Prologue*, has necessarily been withheld to this point on account of limitations in the viola’s range.

To approximate the sound of “white noise” at the climax of *Prologue*, Grisey has the violist play with extreme bow pressure, producing a harsh, scratchy, and unpitched sonority (see Example 3). Understood in the context

²⁷ A detailed analysis of *Prologue* can be found in Baillet 2000, 99–113.

Example 3. Prologue, climax (page 3, systems 8–9)

of spectralist aesthetics and technique, this effect serves a purely functional role. As Grisey notes in connection to instrumental synthesis, spectral music generally makes use of timbres and instrumental effects “on account of the distribution of their energy and not in order to color a harmony or to cobble together a pretty timbre” (2008, 90). Inasmuch as the formal plan of *Prologue* (and of *Les espaces acoustiques* as a whole) requires that there be noise at this point in the work, the use of extreme bow pressure would appear to have no meaning or purpose beyond its capacity to discharge this task.

Spectralist aesthetics and technique are not, however, the only contexts in which this passage may be understood. *Prologue* may just as well be taken as representative of “European avant-garde music,” or, more general still, as representative of “Western art music.” And once the cycle is brought into relation with these larger generic formations, the use of extreme bow pressure assumes an entirely different set of connotations. In the context of the European postwar avant-garde, for instance, the use of such extended instrumental devices, while perhaps not normative, is hardly unexpected—a fact that shifts attention away from the intraopus, formal functions that extreme bow pressure serves, toward the extraopus, intertextual relations it forges with this repertoire. But if the employment of extended instrumental techniques highlights the work’s points of contact with other pieces included in the broader grouping avant-garde music, this is decidedly not the case with regard to the even broader grouping of Western art music. Extreme bow pressure is clearly “marked” in relation to the performance conventions that prevail within this expansive category, a fact that imbues it with a transgressive quality.²⁸ Thus, the climax of *Prologue* becomes something very different depending on whether it is experienced in terms of “spectral,” “avant-garde,” or “classical” musics. But while it is true that different listeners, being in possession of different competences, will prioritize certain groupings over others, such discrepancies in the ordering of relevant contexts do not alter the fact that multiple different contexts will inevitably be in play in listening to this or any other piece of music. And it is the interaction of these multiple layers that is crucial to the peculiar quality that this passage assumes: the distorted timbre of the viola is at once a marked element (from the perspective of Western art music) and an unmarked one (from the perspective of postwar avant-garde music), at once a purely functional device (from the perspective of spectralism) and a stylistic mannerism (again from the perspective of the postwar avant-garde).

Overlaid on this series of nested categories is another, alternative grouping principle. As was the case with instrumental synthesis, the simulation of distortion in this passage implies a fundamental division between “instrumental” music and its “electronic” (or, better, “electric”) counterpart. But in contrast to instrumental synthesis, the technological model emulated here

²⁸ On markedness in music, see Hatten 1994.

may not refer exclusively to the practices of classic, studio-based electroacoustic music but also to those of rock music. This generic cross-reference, and the different set of associations that it imposes, further shapes how the multiple laminations at work in this passage are perceived. Hearing this passage as a simulation of a technologically generated effect—even one associated with the “alien” musical idiom of rock—serves to strengthen the connection to spectral music, especially given the prominence that the employment of such models possesses within the genre’s discourses and practices. Yet this way of hearing the climactic passage of *Prologue* also recalibrates our understanding of what, from the perspective of the Western art music tradition, appears as a breach of conventional viola performance practice. The defamiliarization of the viola’s timbre, while still driven by the exigencies of emulating sounds defined by their opposition to “acoustic” sound sources, also plays off the manifold associations that the allusion to rock carries in tow. The music’s transgression against the norms of traditional string technique, in other words, is colored by the qualities of excess, power, and violence that the employment of distortion in certain rock genres evokes (Walser 1993, 41–44).²⁹

5.

But what of the larger formal processes that subtend *Les espaces acoustiques*? How might the proliferation of groupings invoked above inform how we experience the successive “cycles of respiration” that propel Grisey’s music? One way of answering such questions is to explore in greater detail his notion of “liminality,” one of the three keywords (along with “difference” and “transience”) that Grisey advanced to clarify the aesthetic bases of spectralism.³⁰ Liminal phenomena, Grisey notes, stand at the threshold between two or more qualitatively different states. Instrumental synthesis provides a case in point. Despite the care taken to approximate the frequencies of a spectrum’s upper partials, performers are rarely capable of accurately rendering the microtonal inflections notated in spectralist scores. “Few musicians,” Grisey acknowledges, “can play the eighth of a tone with precision.” This seeming impediment is of little consequence, however, since “our ear integrates, it adjusts the partials and the desired result is obtained: we perceive a synthetic spectrum, and no longer a harmony” (2008, 50). But if this synthetic spectrum is indeed “no longer a harmony,” neither does it entirely succeed in attaining the status of a timbre. Rather, the sonorities generated via instrumental synthesis sit in a no-man’s land between these two perceptual categories, hence Grisey’s claim to have created “a hybrid being for our perception, a sound which, without being a timbre, is already no longer quite a chord—a sort of mutant of contemporary music” (2008, 50–51).

²⁹ For a discussion of the surplus of associations involved in exchanges across generic boundaries, see Kronengold 2008.

³⁰ These concepts are explored in Grisey’s text “La musique: le devenir des sons,” first published in 1982. See Grisey 2008, 45–54.

I noted in the preceding section some of the physical constraints that prevent the individual parts from blending to such a degree that the sonorities produced via instrumental synthesis are able to transcend their liminal status and be heard unambiguously as timbre (the spectral complexity of instrumental parts, performers' "inaccuracies" in timing and intonation, etc.). But physical factors alone do not explain why, in Grisey's words, "traditional instruments naturally resist fusion" (2008, 49). To these must be added a learned, cultural dimension, one that concerns how listeners frame these liminal sonorities. What is crucial in this regard is the familiarity of the ensemble's component timbres for individuals socialized in the Western art music metagenre. That is, the recognizability of individual instruments, along with the associations that each carries in tow, poses yet another obstacle to their coalescence into a single percept—this in spite of Grisey's avowal that in spectral composition the instrument is selected "for its specific [acoustical] qualities and not for its cultural connotation (idyllic flutes, the bucolic oboe, the distant horn, etc.)" (2008, 90). Even if such acculturated associations are rejected at the "poietic" level, banished from the decision-making processes of spectral composition, this does not prevent them from slipping back in at the "esthetic" level, informing listeners' perceptions of both the individual instrumental timbres and the composite sonorities they produce. Grisey can no more dictate which associations listeners bring to bear upon his music than can any other composer.³¹

As a result of the medium's material constraints, on the one hand, and the individual instruments' habitual associations, on the other, the liminal timbre harmonies that mark moments of temporary repose throughout *Les espaces acoustiques* prove fragile, always in danger of dispersing. Yet it is this

31 Which is not to say that a composer like Grisey has no influence over the way listeners approach his music. On the contrary: because of the central position they occupy within the art world of contemporary classical music, composers enjoy a considerable capacity to shape the reception of their works. Here it is vital to bear in mind that framing is not just an individual action but a form of social interaction, typically involving a struggle over how some situation (musical or otherwise) is to be defined. Among the range of "extramusical" resources composers can call upon in framing their music in advance for audiences, titles and other paramusical markers prove particularly effective: the fact that Grisey titled his cycle *Les espaces acoustiques*, for instance, acts as a subtle way of directing the listener's attention toward the music's acoustic dimensions as opposed, say, to its potential social, historical, or cultural significance. The same is true of other texts marshaled to speak on behalf of the otherwise mute work of absolute music. A case in point is to be found in Grisey's program notes to *Transitoires*, the fifth work of *Les espaces acoustiques*. Standing at the center of the piece (at rehearsal 18) is a reprise of the opening gesture of *Partiels*, now real-

ized by an eighty-four-piece orchestra. The image Grisey evokes to describe the relation between *Transitoires* and earlier works in the cycle offers listeners one way of understanding this moment: "By means of its large acoustical field, *Transitoires* . . . realizes what was latent in the other pieces of the cycle: the filter is withdrawn, time is dilated, spectra burst up to the 55th harmonic" (2008, 139). By invoking a technological model (the filter) to describe the relation between the more limited instrumental forces of *Partiels* and the expanded forces of *Transitoires*, Grisey binds the cycle as a whole all the more tightly to the genre of electroacoustic music. But this is not the only way of framing the relation between these two passages. If the relevant context for hearing *Les espaces acoustiques* is taken to be the French symphonic tradition rather than electroacoustic music, for instance, then the reprise of the opening of *Partiels* at rehearsal 18 of *Transitoires* may instead be figured as an example of intermovement cyclicism, with all of the historical and institutional weight that this technique carries in tow. For more on the import of cyclic works for French instrumental music, see Wheeldon 2005.

The image displays a musical score for rehearsal 22 of the piece *Partiels*. The score is arranged in a system with ten staves, each labeled with an instrument: Flute 1, Flute 2, Accordion, Vibraphone, Violin 1, Violin 2, Viola 1, Viola 2, Cello, and Contrabass. The notation includes various musical symbols such as notes, rests, and dynamic markings. The dynamics *ppp* (pianississimo) and *p* (piano) are prominently featured, indicating a very soft and delicate sound. The score is written in a standard musical notation style, with clefs and key signatures visible for each instrument.

Example 4. *Partiels*, rehearsal 22

very fragility that keeps the music moving forward. The dissolution of the fused sound into a heterogeneous collection of individual instruments catalyzes each successive “cycle of respiration,” as the seemingly stable sonority that serves as the goal of the preceding cycle becomes the point of departure for the next. Virtually every major formal juncture of *Les espaces acoustiques* dramatizes such points of inflection. A representative example comes at rehearsal 22 of *Partiels*, the end of the first large-scale “cycle of respiration” in the work (see Example 4). Signaling the moment arrival is the return to the E1’s spectrum for the first time since the opening of the work. At this point the ensemble thins out, leaving only the flutes, strings, vibraphone, and accordion. The strings and the accordion are placed in a high register, sustaining a series of open fifths from E5 to E7. To facilitate the blending of the instruments, Grisey takes care to suppress the distinctive timbral profile of



**Example 5a. *Partiels*, rehearsal
22, virtual descent projected by
staggered crescendos**



**Example 5b. *Partiels*, rehearsal
23, second violin incipit**

each: the first viola is muted, violins and cello play *sul tasto* without vibrato, and the first violin, second viola, cello, and contrabass all play artificial harmonics. Staggered crescendos in the strings create the impression of descending motion, which is repeated ad libitum in quasi-periodic fashion. Meanwhile, the flutes glide up and down between adjacent partials of the EI's spectrum. Flute 1 oscillates between the sixteenth and seventeenth harmonics (E5 and F5), while flute 2 oscillates between the seventh and eighth (D↓4 and E4).

The fragile equilibrium achieved in this passage endures until rehearsal 23, at which point the individual parts subsumed by the global sonority reemerge. As flutes, accordion, and vibraphone withdraw from the texture, the second violin begins playing a line in a normal tone, *molto vibrato*, its incipit echoing the descending motion created by the staggered crescendos in rehearsal 22 (see Examples 5a and 5b). The first viola and first violin join in shortly thereafter, each directed to play *poco vibrato*, followed by other instruments one by one. The result is a complex, Ligeti-esque polyphony, as different instrumental parts overlap and pile on top of one another. But while the increasing intricacy of the texture spells the end of the fused sonority, what appears to trigger this process in the first place is the individuation of the instrumental timbres at rehearsal 23. The use of vibrato is key in this regard, not solely because it is able to help differentiate the parts but because its capacity to do so is overdetermined. Vibrato, in other words, assumes different guises depending on which generic level it is construed. Within a spectral context, vibrato has significance primarily on account of its psychoacoustic properties. Rapid oscillations in frequency and amplitude impede the synchronization of separate voices and, in so doing, impede their fusion into a single, cohesive entity. Heard in terms of the broader context of Western art music, vibrato by contrast serves as a way of reasserting the identity of the

instrumental parts, a way of “refamiliarizing” timbres that the use of mutes, harmonics, and *sul tasto* bowing had previously defamiliarized. Among other things, the application of vibrato at rehearsal 23 has the effect of making the second violin part sound more “substantial” relative to what has come before. And given the strong resemblance between the staggered crescendos’ descending motion at rehearsal 22 and the second violin’s line at rehearsal 23, the effect is akin to a change in the music’s state of being: it is as if the immaterial is materialized, the ethereal come down to earth. Contributing to this effect is vibrato’s status as a signifier of individual expressivity within the Western art music tradition. This entrenched connotation of individual, expressive warmth not only abets the instruments’ perceptual segregation at this moment but also lends this passage a discernable affective charge. Indeed, it is not difficult to hear this passage in allegorical terms, as the emergence of the individual voice out of a fused group.

In a sense, the two ways of framing vibrato in this passage are complementary. In both, the end result is the same: vibrato is heard in one as in the other as the motive force that precipitates the shift from fused sonority to diffuse polyphony, the only major difference residing in how, exactly, it is perceived to trigger this shift. Elsewhere in *Les espaces acoustiques* the interpretations afforded by different generic contexts prove more difficult to reconcile, their interaction being less a matter of mutual reinforcement than of contradiction. Such is the case with the opening of *Partiels*, discussed earlier in connection to the technique of instrumental synthesis. Recall that the work begins with attacks in the trombone and double bass, echoed by a synthetic spectrum whose parts double the individual partials of the trombone’s spectrum. This alternation of “real” and “virtual” spectra is reiterated, with a few minor variations, a handful of times. The first major change to this gesture occurs at rehearsal 1, as the spectral harmony is filled out, now played by the *tutti* ensemble (see Example 6). In addition, the trombone’s low E ceases to coincide with the upbeat rhythmic figure in the double bass, from this point forward falling on the downbeat with the rest of the ensemble. These transformations in the opening gesture mark the point of departure for a gradual process that leads away from the initial state of harmonicity toward increasing levels of inharmonicity.³² Eleven times the alternation of double bass upbeats and spectral harmony is heard following rehearsal 1, but with each repetition the individual components of the global sonority drift away from the position they initially occupied in the spectrum. During the first five statements, the pitches that make up the sonority continue to be drawn from the E overtone series, the only alteration being their displacement to progressively lower registers. With the sixth iteration of the gesture the first inharmonic frequencies enter. Subsequent iterations add more pitches foreign to the E overtone series, at the same time as the downward displace-

³² Grisey 2008, 94, provides a synopsis of this process.

2/4

Fl. picc. 1

Fl. picc. 2

Ob.

B♭ Cl.

A Cl.

Cl. B

Horn

Trbn.

Accord.

1 Glockenspiel
(Vibraphone, si l'instrument
possède l'étendue suffisante)

2

Archi: tutti vibrato ord.

Vn. 1

Vn. 2

Vla. 1

Vla. 2

Vc.

Cb.

8va

ASP

mp senza dim.

mp senza dim.

mp senza dim.

ff

f

pp senza dim.

l.v.

mf

mf

mp

mf

mp

pizz.

ff

ff

Example 6. *Partiels*, rehearsal 1

ment of parts continues. By rehearsal 12, the ensemble has devolved into the sort of simulated distortion heard at the climax of *Prologue*, with the notable difference that Grisey is able to use the expanded instrumental forces of *Partiels* to intensify the effect.

One consequence of this passage from harmonic to inharmonic to noise is that the component parts of the global sonority become increasingly distinct as they stray from the opening spectral model. This stands to reason: without the centripetal force of the harmonic spectrum holding the individual elements in place, their ability to form a (relatively) fused whole is diminished. Yet it is not difficult to hear the dissolution of the sonority as already under way with the entry of the entire ensemble at rehearsal 1. In part this is due to the force with which the instruments attack their notes beginning at this moment. Whereas previously individual pitches had been instructed to enter imperceptibly, presumably in order to minimize the effect of their attack transients, this is no longer the case. As a result, individual parts regain much of the distinctive timbral quality that the attenuation of their attacks had suppressed.

Just as important for the relative diffuseness of the sonority at rehearsal 1—if not more so—is the particular way in which the spectral model is “filled out” by the *tutti* ensemble, and the contradictory implications that this entails. On the one hand, by adding components to the virtual spectrum, Grisey appears to offer the listener a more complete representation of the trombone’s model—and thus one that is, at least in theory, more “faithful” to it.³³ Or so it would seem when construed along spectralist lines. Prior to rehearsal 1, only eight partials are included in the sonority, the highest of these being the twenty-first (represented by the first violin’s A6).³⁴ At rehearsal 1 the spectrum expands to encompass eighteen partials, the highest now being the twenty-fifth (represented by the piccolo’s C6). On the other hand, when heard in terms of the broader metagenre, the more complete realization of the spectral model that takes place here translates into a commensurate increase in the sonority’s “dissonance,” as this term is conventionally understood. The greater number of partials included in the sonority, the greater their proximity in pitch space (especially in the upper registers), the less fused the sonority sounds according to the Western art music tradition’s prevailing standards of consonance and dissonance. The fleshing out of the spectral model that takes place at this moment thus appears to come at the cost of upsetting the fragile equilibrium the sonority previously established. What for spectralism represents a culmination, a more expansive rendering of the trombone’s spectrum, represents a breaking point when experienced

³³ In practice, however, this is clearly not the case. The farther up the spectrum one goes, the finer the discriminations in frequency and dynamic level, making deviations from the trombone’s model both more likely and more pronounced.

³⁴ This count does not include the trombone and double bass upbeats that precede the spectral harmony.

through the filter of the Western art music tradition, being the moment when the sonority reaches and perhaps even surpasses the limits of its cohesion.

But the beginning of the end of this liminal sonority may even predate the entry of the full ensemble at rehearsal 1. No matter how successful the fusion of its components, the “timbre harmony” intoned at the opening of *Partiels* cannot help but recall a dominant ninth chord—albeit one that is distorted by the addition of notes corresponding to the eleventh to the twenty-first partials.³⁵ Or at least this way of hearing the sonority will be the case among listeners familiar with the harmonic language of common practice tonality. Here as elsewhere, how one interprets this “ninth chord” depends on how it is framed. In the context of the postwar avant-garde, this chord, like all tertian-based harmonies, is decidedly nonnormative. This status is thrown into relief by the arrival of the more “dissonant” sonority at rehearsal 1, which appears within the latter context as unmarked relative to the more “consonant” sonority of the opening. Read through the lens of the broader art music metagenre, however, the relation between these two sonorities is reversed: viewed from this angle, the opening “ninth chord” is fairly commonplace, unmarked relative to the more fully fleshed-out spectrum of rehearsal 1. (A spectralist reading would presumably seek to transcend these contrasting assessments, maintaining that both sonorities represent two aspects of the same underlying model, the only difference being the degree of magnification it has undergone.)

Figure 3 offers a way of visualizing these contradictory framings of the two sonorities. Further complicating these divergent framings is the fact that even within the broader context of the Western art music tradition, the “dominant ninth” heard at the outset is open to a number of contrasting interpretations. Once again, how one hears this sonority will vary according to the contexts in which it is placed—which is to say that it will vary according to the different kinds of music with which it is grouped. Should listeners connect the opening of *Partiels* to the music of early-twentieth-century French composers like Debussy and Ravel, for instance, the grouping thereby enacted will encourage hearing the “dominant ninth” in nonfunctional terms, as a coloristic device. But should listeners bring this passage into relation with other repertoires encompassed by the art music metagenre, with musics that allow some measure of the latent functionality of the “dominant ninth” to glimmer through, this will no doubt imbue the sonority with an air of instability, however faint this may be. Heard in these terms, the sonority that opens *Partiels* appears to possess a dynamic potential it lacks when heard purely and simply in spectral terms, as nothing other than a macrophonic projection of the trombone’s microphonic spectrum. Needless to say, these

³⁵ These “extra” notes are played at such a soft dynamic that it is unlikely that they will preclude hearing the sonority as a dominant ninth.

	Spectral	Postwar avant-garde	Western art music
“Rehearsal 0”	Partial synthesis of trombone E1 (=)	Dominant ninth (+)	Dominant ninth (–)
Rehearsal 1	Fuller synthesis of trombone E1 (=)	Dissonant sonority (–)	Dissonant sonority (+)

Percepts in the table are designated as marked (+), unmarked (–), or neutral (=).

Figure 3. Contradictory interpretations of *Partiels*, opening and rehearsal 1

discrepant interpretations are by no means mutually exclusive: as noted above, familiarity with a range of genres and metagenres means that most listeners will be able to entertain multiple contradictory ways of hearing the same sonority at one and the same time. Indeed, it is this semiotic indeterminacy that accounts for the particular piquancy of the sonority that opens *Partiels*—and which explains why it has attracted so much attention from composers, critics, and scholars over the years.

But while the opening of *Partiels* is capable of supporting multiple simultaneous readings, even contradictory ones, not all of these will be regarded as equally viable. The value and weight attached to the myriad groupings to which *Les espaces acoustiques* is subject, and the myriad contexts in which it may be placed, depend as much on the competences, investments, and interests of the individual listener as on the music’s objective properties. It comes as little surprise, then, that hearing the opening sonority of *Partiels* as a dominant ninth—that is, in light of the principal harmonic framework within the Western art music tradition—represents for some devotees of spectral music a willful distortion of what is “really” going on in the music. Such is the case with composer Philippe Hurel:

Despite the audible success of the first section of *Partiels* at the level of “synthesis,” a musically trained listener hears a third, a fifth, a seventh, a ninth; how are we to name the harmonics of a sound if not by their musical designation? To make the leap from this to hearing them in terms of a chord-type seems to me to come close to a perversion of the ear, an ear that would be tonal: the superposition of a fundamental and its harmonics does not “sound” like a dominant ninth chord, so long as one understands that the musical context has connoted nothing of the sort (1991, 263).³⁶

36 A somewhat different reading of Hurel’s remark has been proposed by Brian Kane. He convincingly describes Hurel’s rejection of a tonal understanding of this sonority as symptomatic of spectralism’s allergy to musical signification or connotation: for Hurel “the chord cannot connote anything because connotation is itself the problem for Spectralism” (2004, 132). Elsewhere Kane expands upon this observation, arguing that the gradual drift away from the E spectrum from rehearsal 1 to rehearsal 12 of *Partiels*

acts as a way of slowly effacing the tonal associations that the sonority possesses at the outset: “Hearing the opening chord as a dominant ninth is a seductive possibility that Grisey must flirt with, he must offer it up to the listener, in order for it to be slowly taken away” (2006, 89). By using the varied repetitions that ensue to strip the sonority of these connotations, Grisey is able to stage a phenomenological reduction of the spectrum for the listener.

Leaving aside for the moment Hurel's tendentious assumption that the work alone provides the only relevant "musical context" for hearing this passage, it is worth noting that, in dismissing a more conventional reading of this sonority, he tacitly acknowledges that such a reading is not only possible but also likely. Otherwise, why go through the trouble of denouncing it? To say that a stretch of music should be heard in terms of one genre and not another presupposes that multiple genres are indeed in play and that certain of these need to be suppressed in order to allow for the one that affords a "true" or "proper" understanding of the music to go about its business, free of interference or complication. In short, it is to replace description with prescription. But were we to admit that there are other contexts for hearing this passage beyond those provided by the work itself or the spectralist aesthetic it is said to exemplify, then a fuller, more complicated, and altogether more *realistic* understanding of how individuals engage with this and other passages of *Les espaces acoustiques* comes into view. Determining whether this sonority is better interpreted as a ninth chord or as a virtual spectrum would no longer be the focus of analytic concern. Rather, what would be at stake is determining the conditions of possibility that enable such contrasting interpretations to arise, the manner in which listeners negotiate and bring such divergent percepts into alignment, and the contingencies that lead individuals to prioritize one at the expense of the other.

6.

Hurel's remarks bring us full circle, inasmuch as they partake of the same set of beliefs that underpin the "decline of genre" thesis discussed in the introduction. His supposition that the proper context for understanding Grisey's music is provided by the work and the work alone is perfectly consistent with the conviction that broader generic groupings are of limited utility in coming to grips with modernist music. But as I have sought to demonstrate over the course of this article, the idea that comprehension of this repertoire is seldom facilitated by "familiarity with 'stylistic' norms" (Dubiel 1992, 121) is itself a normative belief.³⁷ The renunciation of generic conventions is modernism's founding convention, just as the capacity to recognize that acquired competences no longer apply to this repertoire depends on the listener's prior acquisition of a special kind of "modernist" competence.³⁸ In other words, hearing

³⁷ As Charles Kronengold astutely observes, one of the most important conventions operative within any genre has to do with the role and meaning it attaches to conventions: "It goes without saying that different genres possess different conventions, but we should add that the uses and understandings of conventions vary across genres as well" (2008, 56). In this regard Kronengold's remark that new wave betrays "a hypersensitivity to the conventions of other genres along with a blindness to the ways

that its own practices begin to congeal into conventions" (61) applies to much contemporary classical music, even if the specific strategies adopted in response to this "hypersensitivity" differ tremendously.

³⁸ It is useful to recall here Bourdieu's discussion of the incomprehension that the antiart transgressions of the avant-garde at times elicit among "untrained" spectators. Describing how the exhibition of a pile of coal by Ben

a work like *Les espaces acoustiques* on its own terms (or, at the limit, as a representative of spectral music) involves more than just approaching it with an open mind and with open ears. Even for the listener who has thoroughly assimilated the modernist convention of disavowing convention, even for the analyst who successfully adheres to the preconception of having no preconceptions, attaining this sublime state of receptivity is not something that occurs automatically. Rather, it demands the active suppression of acquired cultural knowledge. To the extent that expectations relating to other potential groupings (and to the genres that they entail) may be absent for listeners, it is only because they are absented, bracketed out as illegitimate or inessential.

But if a condition of “cultural virginity” (Menger 1983, 275) is the ideal toward which spectralism and other modernist genres aspire (at least with regard to their reception), it is uncertain how often this ideal is realized. What remains unclear is the ability of listeners and analysts to turn different competences on and off like a spigot. Clearly, this is a question that can be satisfactorily answered only by means of empirical research, be it ethnography, reception histories, experimental testing, or quantitative surveys. But as my discussion of *Les espaces acoustiques* has no doubt already intimated, I suspect that the multiple competences individuals possess are not as easily dissociated in practice as they are in theory. And if this proves to be the case, then it has implications that extend beyond the analysis and interpretation of modernist music, inasmuch as every piece of music is subject to multiple competing groupings, capable of being aligned with a number of genres of varying shapes and sizes at one and the same time.

Consider, for instance, the late romantic works that are the principal (but not exclusive) object of concern for neo-Riemannian theory. One of the sources of this theory’s appeal lies in its ability to demonstrate the logic of harmonic progressions that, from the perspective of traditional diatonic tonal theory, appear to be lacking such logic. When confronted with passages that are “not fully coherent according to the principles of diatonic tonality,” neo-Riemannian theory seeks to determine “by what other principles” such music is able to cohere (Cohn 1998, 169). Yet the subset of works that neo-Riemannian theory constitutes as a distinct grouping will no doubt be regarded by most listener as being embedded in a larger grouping in turn (romantic music), which is itself embedded in other, higher-order groupings (“common practice” music, Western art music, etc.). As with the modernist

Vautier at the Centre Georges Pompidou induced in certain viewers “confusion,” verging on a state of “panic mingled with revolt,” he observes that the exhibition’s “parodic intention” is “entirely defined in terms of an artistic field and its relatively autonomous history” (1984, 33). Thus, the revulsion that greeted Vautier’s piece was due to a recognition among nonelite viewers that the meanings of such gestures “derive their necessity from the logic of a field of production which excludes them” (33). Put in slightly differ-

ent terms, one might say that the impact of this and other pieces of antiart derives from their self-conscious disavowal of a certain kind of cultural competence. Lacking this competence, one is shut out of the work and rendered unable to assess it properly, since the act of negation it performs relies upon one’s tacit knowledge of the positivity that precedes and thereby enables it (i.e., the “art” denied by “antiart”).

genres discussed in this article, these multiple affiliations suggest that the progressions that are the focus of much neo-Riemannian research can and will be heard in a number of ways: in terms of their local generic context, with its emphasis on voice-leading parsimony as a principal means of ensuring musical coherence, as well as their broader, metageneric context, with its continuing reliance on functional harmonic progression. It is not that the sense of “unity” afforded by a neo-Riemannian perspective dispels the sense of “disunity” that a diatonic-tonal framework imposes on such music. Rather, it is that the two interpretive matrices stand in a state of uneasy coexistence.³⁹ That the music gathered under the rubric of “triadic post-tonality” has the capacity to sustain multiple, contradictory readings—itself a product of its capacity to sustain multiple, contradictory frames—may help to explain the peculiar hermeneutic qualities it possesses (including the uncanny character that Richard Cohn aptly attributes to progressions juxtaposing hexatonic poles).⁴⁰

Taking into account the numerous groupings that pieces of music afford—and the numerous generic frames listeners are able to mobilize as a consequence—may also provide a useful complement to recent efforts at weaning music theory from the unreflected assumptions that continue to inform its practices: its overly narrow conception of what counts as musical structure (Lochhead 2006); its susceptibility to the “poietic fallacy,” with its problematic conflation of artistic value with compositional complexity or craftsmanship (Taruskin 2004); its dissociation of “stylistic” and “structural” forms of listening (Subotnik 1996); its disregard for the interactive character of musical encounters (Guck 2006); and its attachment to such hoary ideological constructs as the unified work (Korsyn 1999, 2003). Theories of musical intertextuality, for instance, have done much to reveal the degree to which “the frontiers of music are never clear-cut,” the putative unity of the work being at best “variable and relative” (Klein 2005, 4). The revised understanding of genre advanced here might serve to further refine such insights. On the one hand, established genre categories often function as an implicit constraint upon which kinds of intertextual relations are recognized as valid. The title of Michael Klein’s *Intertextuality in Western Art Music* (2005), for example, effectively marks off the boundaries in which the free play of the intertextual imagination is allowed to roam—notwithstanding Klein’s declaration that the “references of . . . music to other music are potentially unlimited” (11). On the other hand, greater attentiveness to genre might disclose some of the unreflected assumptions that continue to inform intertextual and poststructural-inspired theories of music. While such theories have pointed

39 For an illuminating discussion of the constitutive ambivalence of neo-Riemannian theory—that is, its tendency to prioritize atypical harmonic progressions at the same time as it seeks to normalize them—see Rings 2011, 497–500.

40 This is suggested by Cohn’s own comments on the *Unheimlichkeit* of hexatonic poles, namely, his remark that this quality depends on the progression’s interpretation in terms of “the cognitive expectations of the fluent listener to tonal music” (2004, 318).

a way past the idealizations of the unified work—along with the particular form of “cryptosubjectivity” (Korsyn 1999, 2003) to which such idealizations give rise⁴¹—they remain attached to the figure of the individual, manifest in a methodological commitment to the individual text as the primary unit of analysis. Even if an intertext happens to tie texts together to form a larger, “potentially unlimited” network, this does not alter the fact that the individual text is the point from which these ramifying connections depart and invariably return; and this suggests that intertextual and poststructural approaches to music analysis have not dispelled the specter of cryptosubjectivity as much as substituted one of its many forms for another. No longer is the comforting fantasy image of the self projected by the work defined in terms of a unity and self-identity that compensates for the fragility of the modern subject; now it is defined in terms of fluency in a particular style and the virtuosic display of symbolic mastery that such knowledge makes possible.⁴²

But perhaps the most significant gain to be won from a renewed focus on genre is that it provides a point of entry for considering how the plural and agonistic character of the cultural field, by imprinting itself upon ourselves, shapes our perception and understanding of music. A guiding assumption throughout the present article has been that this plural condition, far from being something that pertains exclusively to relations between different texts, different genres, and different subject positions, is in fact to be found in each of these: it is not just the unity and self-identity of the work that is in question but the various genres to which it can be brought into relation, and the various actors who participate in its production, circulation, and interpretation. Texts, genres, agents: each of these is “more than one, and less than many,” to borrow a phrase from anthropologist Marilyn Strathern (cited in Mol 2002, 82). There is nothing particularly novel in saying this. Claims regarding the immanent heterogeneity of the text have become a commonplace in the wake of poststructuralism, as the theories of intertextuality cited above attest. Likewise, claims regarding the divided consciousness of the modern subject are hardly unprecedented, being a staple of such diverse intellectual discourses as post-Freudian psychoanalysis and postcolonial theory. But while there has been a marked effort within the disciplines of music theory and analysis to consider the implications that follow from the dispersal of the text, markedly less attention has been paid in the field to the question of how the

⁴¹ The notion of cryptosubjectivity invoked by Kevin Korsyn derives from the work of Terry Eagleton, who contends that the valorization of the unified, autonomous artwork in post-Enlightenment aesthetics served a covert ideological function, acting as “a symbol or prop for the often precarious identity of the individual” (Korsyn 2003, 43).

⁴² It would be a mistake, however, to believe that a reconsideration of genre would somehow liberate analysis from the sort of fantasy projection identified by Korsyn. Indeed, it could very well be argued that the approach I have advo-

cated here involves similar displays of symbolic mastery, by projecting the image of a subject who has achieved sufficient critical distance to possess a detached, synoptic view of the musical field in its totality. But the point is not to engage in the ultimately quixotic effort at elaborating a theory that would in some way preclude such fantasies altogether. The point is to be cognizant of the investments that different theories afford and the ideological work they perform as a result.

multiple musical competences individuals possess inform their experience of specific events, texts, and practices. Conversely, while work in musicology, ethnomusicology, and the sociology of music over the past twenty years has examined “the multiple identifications . . . to which individuals are susceptible” (Born 2000, 33), with an eye to showing how these participate in processes of identity formation, acts of musical (self-)representation, and strategies of cultural distinction, this has not translated into a comparable examination of the impact that such divided musical loyalties exercise upon the experience and interpretation of music. What is lacking—and hence what is needed—is a musical semiotics that does not presume a univocal correspondence of code and competence but instead accounts for the diverse forms of cultural knowledge that individuals possess and the equally diverse ways in which these interact and interfere with one another. What is needed is a hermeneutics that does not presume a single, undivided horizon of expectation but one that is fissured, internally heterogeneous, divided between a range of competing allegiances and investments. What is needed is an analytic method better equipped to grapple with the dynamics of “splitting and denial at work . . . in the musical imaginary” (Born 2000, 38), that is able to register the effects of “the struggle of the self against oneself” (Lahire 2005)—a splitting and a struggle evident in the way Hurel recognizes the possibility of a “common practice” interpretation of the opening of *Partiels* at the same time as he refuses to grant it legitimacy. The reassessment of genre that I have undertaken in this article, with its emphasis on the performative and relational character of musical categories, and the framing effects that such fluid categories afford, contributes to this broader theoretical project.

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